

AP Latin: The Complete Exam Guide

The revised Vergil and Pliny syllabus explained, the course project passages, translation and essay playbooks, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**3 hrs**

65 min multiple choice
+ 115 min free response

52+5

multiple-choice +
free-response questions

2 authors

Vergil and
Pliny the Younger

59–73%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, one score

Your AP score (1–5) combines a multiple-choice section and a free-response section, each worth half. Both test syllabus passages from Vergil and Pliny and your ability to read Latin at sight.

50%

Section I • Multiple choice • 52 questions

50%

Section II • Free response • 5 questions

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I • Multiple choice	50% of score 1 hr 5 min 52 questions	Discrete questions, short sets and long sets on syllabus passages and unseen (sight) passages, plus Roman history and culture.
II • Free response	50% of score 1 hr 55 min 5 questions	A set of short-answer questions on a syllabus passage • a literal translation • a short analytical essay • two short essays summarizing and interpreting prose and poetry from the course project passages.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

IN-CLASS CHECKPOINTS

Two tasks during the year

Two **in-class checkpoints**, a summary-writing task and an interpretive product, count for **2% of your final AP score**. Check deadlines with your teacher.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

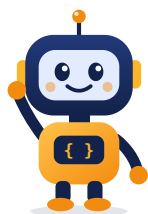
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 14 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Read Latin **every day**, even 10 lines. Sight-reading speed comes from volume, not from memorizing translations.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

52 questions in 65 minutes gives you about 1 minute 15 seconds per question, including reading time for each passage.

52

questions on syllabus and sight passages

1:15

minutes per question, including reading

50%

of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

What the questions draw on

College Board does not publish exact weights; bars show the relative emphasis students can expect.

Syllabus

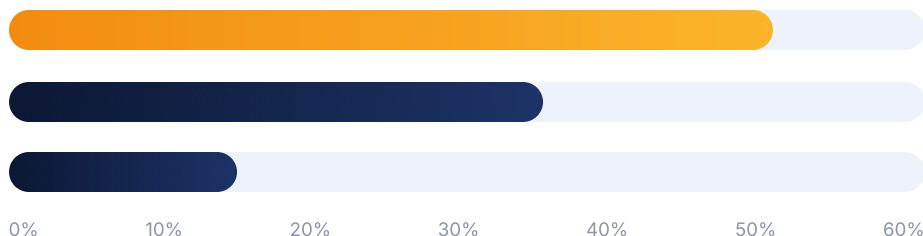
Vergil and Pliny passages

Sight

Unseen prose and poetry

Context

Roman history & culture

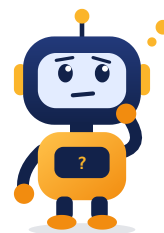


What this means for your study time: Know the syllabus passages very well, but practice sight reading weekly; unseen passages can't be memorized.

Strategies that work on this section

- Find the **main verb first**, then its subject and object.
- Use **endings, not word order**, to decide case and function.
- Know your **grammar labels**: ablative absolute, indirect statement, purpose and result clauses, gerundives.
- For **scansion**, mark long syllables by nature and position before counting feet.
- Read the **whole sentence** before choosing a translation; context decides meaning.
- Never leave a blank**. There is no penalty for guessing.

Latin word order is **flexible**. Let the endings, not the position, tell you who does what.



03

WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 6 units & required readings

The revised course pairs Vergil's *Aeneid* with Pliny the Younger's *Letters*, plus teacher-chosen readings and yearly project passages.

UNIT

1

Teacher's Choice: Latin Prose

Be ready to: review forms and syntax; read longer prose passages to build reading fluency.

UNIT

2

Pliny: The Eruption of Vesuvius

Be ready to: read the two letters about Mount Vesuvius (79 CE) and the death of Pliny the Elder.

UNIT

3

Pliny: Other Letters

Be ready to: letters on the supernatural, Trajan and Calpurnia; Roman social life and values.

UNIT

4

Teacher's Choice Poetry + Aeneid 1-2

Be ready to: introduction to Latin poetry and meter; Aeneas, Juno and the fall of Troy.

UNIT

5

Aeneid 4, 6, 7, 11, 12

Be ready to: Dido and Aeneas; the underworld; war in Italy; the poem's ending.

UNIT

6

Course Project + Teacher's Choice

Be ready to: four project passages unique to each year: read, translate and analyze them.

Using older review books? The revised course no longer includes Caesar's *De Bello Gallico*. Focus your review on Vergil, Pliny and sight reading.

04 SECTION II The 5 free-response questions

115 minutes for 5 questions. Translation rewards literal accuracy; the essays reward Latin evidence with clear interpretation.

Short answer

Translation

Analytical essay

Short essay 1

Short essay 2

In-class checkpoints count for 2% of your final AP score

SA

Short-answer set

6–8 questions on a syllabus passage

Answer questions on grammar, meaning, context and style, citing the Latin.

Quote the exact Latin words that support each answer.

Tr

Translation

Literal

Translate a syllabus passage as literally as possible. Each segment is scored for accuracy.

Keep every word's case, tense and number; don't paraphrase.

AE

Short analytical essay

Interpretation

Interpret a syllabus passage, supporting your argument with Latin cited and translated or closely paraphrased.

Cite line numbers and analyze style, not just content.

SE

Two short essays

Project passages

Summarize and interpret prose and poetry from the year's course project passages.

Prepare the project passages as thoroughly as the syllabus.

◆ A time plan for the 115 minutes

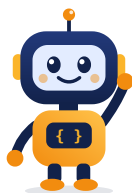
Short answer
~20 min

Translation
~15 min

Analytical essay
~35 min

Short essays
~45 min

Suggested timing. Check the timing shown in Bluebook on exam day.



In translation, **literal beats elegant**. Every case ending and tense must show in your English.

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

05

Anatomy of a strong answer

Here is a short-answer style task on the opening of the *Aeneid*, with full-credit answers annotated.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice task: Read *Aeneid* 1.1–4. Arma virumque canō, Trōiae quī prīmus ab ōrīs
 Ītaliā, fātō profugus, Lāvīniaque vēnit
 lītora, multum ille et terrīs iactātus et altō
 vī superum saevae memorem lūnōnis ob īram; (a) Translate "fātō profugus." (b) Identify the case and use of "altō."
 (c) Explain how the poet characterizes Juno in line 4, citing the Latin.

Full-credit answers

- ① (a) "an exile by fate" (fātō is an ablative of cause or means).
- ② (b) "altō" is ablative of place where, without a preposition (poetic): "on the deep sea".
- ③ (c) Juno is "saevae" (cruel) and her anger is "memorem" (mindful, unforgetting).
- ④ Vergil blames Aeneas's suffering, "multum... iactātus," directly on Juno's "īram", framing her as a relentless divine enemy from the poem's first lines.

- ① **Literal translation** with the case reflected.
- ② **Name the case and its use** precisely.
- ③ **Cite the Latin** and translate it.
- ④ **Interpret:** connect word choice to meaning.

Five habits for every free-response answer

1

Cite Latin for every claim, with line numbers.

2

Translate or closely paraphrase every citation.

3

Keep translations literal: case, tense, number.

4

Prepare project passages as well as the syllabus.

5

Stuck? Translate what you can; each segment scores.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

The first noun is the **subject!** (Not in Latin.)



01 Reading in English word order

Latin word order is flexible. Use endings to find the subject and object.

02 Ablative confusion

Ablatives can show means, manner, time, place or cause. Context decides which.

03 Missing an ablative absolute

A noun and participle in the ablative, set off from the main clause, usually form an ablative absolute.

04 Indirect statement

After verbs of saying or thinking, look for an accusative subject and an infinitive.

05 Purpose vs result

Both use ut + subjunctive. A tam, ita or tantus in the main clause usually signals result.

06 Free translation

Paraphrasing loses points. Keep each word's grammatical form visible.

07 Elision in scansion

A final vowel or vowel + m elides before a word starting with a vowel or h.

08 Essays without Latin

Every claim in an essay needs Latin evidence, cited and translated.

09 Studying old syllabus texts

Caesar is no longer on the syllabus. Focus on Vergil and Pliny.

10 Ignoring sight reading

Unseen passages appear on the exam. Practice weekly.

Quick self-check: in "Petis ut tibi avunculī meī exitum scrībam," what kind of clause is "ut... scrībam," and who is the uncle? (An indirect command; Pliny the Elder.)

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Read Latin every day and practice sight reading weekly.



Sep – Oct
Prose



Units 1–2

Grammar review and Pliny's Vesuvius letters. Start a vocabulary list from the syllabus.

Nov – Dec
Pliny



Unit 3

Other letters of Pliny; Roman society. Practice literal translation weekly.

Jan – Feb
Vergil



Unit 4: Aeneid 1–2 meter

Introduction to dactylic hexameter and the opening books. Begin analytical essays.

Mar – Apr
Vergil + project



Units 5–6

Aeneid 4, 6, 7, 11, 12 and the year's project passages. Complete in-class checkpoints.

Early May
Sharpen



Full timed sections

Sight passages, translation and essays under timing.

Exam day
May



AP Latin exam • Bluebook

Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one sight passage set and one translation	List weakest syntax areas
3 weeks out	Daily: 20 lines of syllabus review, one sight passage	Literal translations every time
2 weeks out	Full 3-hour practice exam	Finish every question
Final week	Light review: syntax labels, project passages, traps	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **14 minutes** for all ten, then check page 11.

1 VERGIL • AENEID 1.1–4

Questions 1–6 refer to the passage below.

Arma virumque canō, Trōiae quī prīmus ab ōrīs
Ītaliā, fātō profugus, Lāvīniaque vēnit
lītora, multum ille et terrīs iactātus et altō
vī superum saevae memorem Iūnōnis ob iram;

Vergil, Aeneid 1.1–4

In line 1, "virum" refers to:

- A Aeneas
- B Jupiter
- C Vergil
- D Augustus

2 SYNTAX

In line 1, "Trōiae" is in which case?

- A Nominative
- B Dative
- C Genitive
- D Ablative

3 TRANSLATION

The best translation of "fātō profugus" (line 2) is:

- A fleeing from fate
- B an exile by fate
- C the fate of the exile
- D fated to flee

4 METER

The meter of the passage is:

- A iambic trimeter
- B Elegiac couplet
- C Hendecasyllabic
- D Dactylic hexameter

5 MEANING

In line 3, "altō" most likely means:

- A the deep sea
- B the high mountain
- C the tall man
- D the old city

6 CONTENT

According to line 4, why was Aeneas tossed about?

- A Because he angered Jupiter
- B Because the Trojans lost the war at sea
- C On account of the unforgetting anger of cruel Juno
- D Because Venus abandoned him

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

7 PLINY • LETTERS 6.16

Questions 7–9 refer to the sentence below.

Petis ut tibi avunculī meī exitum scribam, quō vērius trādere posterīs possīs.

Pliny the Younger, Letters 6.16

The clause "ut tibi... exitum scribam" is best described as:

- A** A result clause
- B** An indirect command
- C** A temporal clause
- D** An indirect question

8 CONTENT

The "avunculus" whose death Pliny describes is:

- A** the emperor Trajan
- B** the historian Tacitus
- C** his wife's grandfather
- D** Pliny the Elder

9 SYNTAX

"quō vērius trādere posterīs possīs" is best described as:

- A** a result clause
- B** an ablative absolute
- C** a relative purpose clause using quō with a comparative
- D** a conditional sentence

10 CONTEXT

Pliny wrote his letters about the eruption of Vesuvius to which historian?

- A** Livy
- B** Suetonius
- C** Sallust
- D** Tacitus

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	A • Aeneas	The poem's hero, Aeneas, is the man who first came from the shores of Troy to Italy.
2	C • Genitive	"Trōiae ab ōrīs": from the shores <i>of</i> Troy. Trōiae is genitive singular.
3	B	Profugus means "exile"; fātō is ablative of cause or means: "an exile by fate".
4	D	The Aeneid is written in dactylic hexameter, the meter of epic poetry.
5	A	"Terrīs... et altō" pairs land and sea: Aeneas was tossed on lands and on the deep (sea).
6	C	"Saevae memorem lūnōnis ob īram": on account of the unforgetting (mindful) anger of cruel Juno.
7	B	After a verb of asking (petis), ut + subjunctive forms an indirect command.
8	D	Pliny's uncle, Pliny the Elder, died during the eruption of Vesuvius in 79 CE.
9	C	Quō + comparative (vērius) + subjunctive introduces a purpose clause: "so that you may more truthfully...".
10	D • Tacitus	Letters 6.16 and 6.20 were written to Tacitus, who asked for an account for his history.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Drill noun and verb endings, then read 10 lines of syllabus Latin daily.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 59–73% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Latin, and about 13–20% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

59–73%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

13–20%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ In-class **checkpoints** completed and submitted on time
- ☐ Plan your time: about **75 s** per multiple-choice question; follow the free-response timing in Bluebook
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review the **year's project passages** the night before

In the free-response section: translate literally with every case and tense visible, cite Latin with line numbers for every essay claim, translate or paraphrase each citation, and interpret style as well as content.



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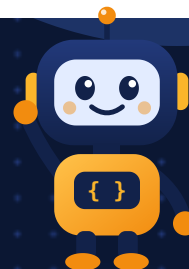
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Timed exam practice

Full-length multiple-choice sets with score reports, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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